

Harry Potter & Edinburgh - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

Wizards in Edinburgh

Of all the literary ghosts in this city, and you've heard how crowded that field is, the one your kids can actually feel is the boy wizard. Harry Potter is an Edinburgh story from start to finish, in a way few people quite realize.

Start with the arrival. December, nineteen ninety-three. A twenty-eight-year-old named Joanne Rowling steps off a train with her infant daughter and, in her suitcase, three chapters of a novel about a wizard school. Her marriage in Portugal has collapsed. She's come to Edinburgh because her sister lives here, and she has almost nothing else. Within months she's a single mother on state benefits, writing in cafes while the baby sleeps in the pram beside her, because writing time exists only when the baby naps. The book she finishes here gets rejected by twelve publishers before a small advance from Bloomsbury changes everything.

Now jump ahead. January, two thousand and seven. The same woman, now the most famous author alive, checks into a suite at the Balmoral Hotel to write the final chapters of the seventh and last book. The entire arc, from broke to the bestselling writer on the planet, from first chapters to final sentence, runs through this one city. All seven books were substantially written here.

Edinburgh has responded the way cities do, with a thriving industry of Potter pilgrimage sites, some genuine, some pure invention. That's the fun of it. Over the next few chapters we'll visit the cafes where she really wrote, and the one whose famous claim she publicly corrected. We'll go looking for Voldemort's gravestone, walk the technicolor street half the internet calls Diagon Alley, and hear what Rowling herself says about all of it, which is usually not what the tour guides say. Then we'll follow the story to its ending, in room five five two, and out to the Highlands, where Hogwarts itself is supposed to stand.

The Cafes, the Legend, and What Rowling Actually Said

The most contested piece of real estate in Potter tourism is a cafe window. For years, The Elephant House on George IV Bridge displayed a sign reading Birthplace of Harry Potter, and for years, thousands of fans photographed it, queued for it, and wrote their devotions on the walls of its toilets, which became a shrine of graffiti in a dozen languages. It's a lovely cafe with a knockout view of the castle from the back room. It is also, on the birthplace claim, wrong, and we know because Rowling finally said so herself.

Her correction, posted on Twitter in twenty twenty, was gentler than it might have been. She'd been writing Potter for several years before she ever set foot in the place, she said, so it's not the birthplace, but she did write there, so, in her words, we'll let them off. The actual conception is well documented. The idea arrived fully formed in nineteen ninety, on a delayed Manchester to London train, and the earliest chapters were written in London, in a flat in Clapham. By the time she reached Edinburgh in late nineteen ninety-three, Harry, Ron and Hermione already existed.

The cafe that has the strongest genuine claim barely gets tourists at all, because it no longer exists. Nicolson's Cafe occupied a first-floor room at the corner of Nicolson Street and Drummond Street, and it

was co-owned by Rowling's brother-in-law, a man named Roger Moore, no relation to James Bond. That family connection mattered. A woman nursing a single espresso for two hours while filling notebooks is a poor customer anywhere else. Here, nobody minded. Large portions of *Philosopher's Stone* were written at those tables, baby asleep alongside. The premises have since cycled through several restaurants, most recently Chinese, but a plaque on the Drummond Street corner marks the spot. When Nicolson's later became a bistro called Spoon, Rowling fans kept coming anyway, which tells you something about the gravitational pull of this story.

As for the Elephant House, fate handed it a dramatic third act. In August twenty twenty-one, a fire that started in a neighboring building gutted the cafe, and it stayed shut for more than four years while the block was rebuilt. The table Rowling wrote at survived, was restored, and when the cafe finally reopened in late December twenty twenty-five, it went back into the room where she used to sit, beneath a portrait of her that now hangs alongside Ian Rankin, Alexander McCall Smith and Irvine Welsh, three more writers who worked in that same room over the years. Which is the honest version of the cafe's claim, and frankly the better one. Not the birthplace of Harry Potter, but a genuine working cafe of the Edinburgh book trade, where at least four internationally bestselling authors have sat scribbling over coffee. The marketing sign was a stretch. The room itself never needed it.

The Graveyard of Names

Greyfriars Kirkyard has been collecting stories since the fifteen hundreds. Covenanters were imprisoned here, grave robbers prowled here, and a small dog allegedly kept vigil here for fourteen years. But the graves that draw the longest lines today belong to people nobody had heard of twenty-five years ago, because fans decided they were the secret ingredients of Harry Potter.

The star attraction is against the far wall, along the path toward the gate into Heriot's grounds. A worn stone commemorates Thomas Riddell Esquire, who died in eighteen oh six at the age of seventy-two, and below him his son, also Thomas Riddell, a young captain of the fourteenth regiment who died at Trinidad in the West Indies in eighteen oh two, aged twenty-six. Riddell, two Ls, but say it aloud and you've said the name of Tom Riddle, the boy who becomes Lord Voldemort. The stone is now one of the most visited graves in Scotland. You'll spot the worn grass leading to it, and fans occasionally leave notes, some of them apologizing to the real Riddells for the association.

Nearby, the supporting cast. William McGonagall, widely celebrated as the worst poet in the history of the English language, a Dundee weaver whose recitals were so gloriously awful that audiences pelted him with vegetables. He died poor in Edinburgh in nineteen oh two and lies here. Professor McGonagall's surname is genuinely his; Rowling has written that she borrowed the name of the terrible poet deliberately, enjoying the thought of the formidably brilliant professor sharing it. And there's a stone for one Elizabeth Moodie, which fans have adopted on behalf of Mad-Eye Moody.

So did Rowling harvest names here on her writing breaks? The Elephant House is barely two minutes away, and the theory writes itself, which is precisely why you should distrust it. In twenty twenty-two she addressed it directly, and her answer was deflating. She'd never taken the tour. One of her own children went on a Potter walking tour of Edinburgh for a laugh, and came home, in Rowling's telling, with a ton of information that was news to her. What she has conceded, in interviews going back to the nineties, is that she was a magpie for unusual names, collecting them from war memorials, phone books, maps and, yes, gravestones. So the honest version is this. The Riddell connection is possible, unconfirmed, and unknowable, perhaps even to Rowling. The McGonagall name is real but came from the poet's fame, not his headstone. The rest is legend, and the tour guides' certainty is theater.

Before you leave, look southwest over the wall at the fairy-tale pile of turrets and chimneys rising beyond. That's George Heriot's School, built through the sixteen hundreds with the fortune of George Heriot, goldsmith to King James the Sixth, as a school for orphaned boys. It still gives free places to children

who've lost parents. Its pupils are sorted into four houses with color identities, and it looks more like Hogwarts than anything the films built. The claim that it inspired Hogwarts is everywhere in Edinburgh, and Rowling has never endorsed it. Her standing line about such claims is that she's never even seen most of the places said to have inspired her. Still, as you stand in a graveyard beside a turreted school for children, with Voldemort's name on a stone behind you, you can see why this city stopped asking her permission.

Diagon Alley and the Legend Machine

Victoria Street may be the most photographed hundred meters in Scotland. It sweeps down from George IV Bridge to the Grassmarket in one long candy-colored curve, shopfronts in red and blue and mustard yellow, with a second tier of shops running along a terrace above. The composition is so good it looks art-directed, and in a sense it was. The street is a planned piece of eighteen twenties and thirties town improvement, built to replace the West Bow, a notoriously steep zigzag lane that had connected the Grassmarket to the high town since medieval times. It was renamed for the new queen, Victoria, in eighteen thirty-seven.

Today the street has effectively been annexed by the wizarding world. There's a Potter merchandise emporium at number forty styling itself Diagon House, another Potter shop further up, and a steady congregation of visitors framing the same downhill photograph, because everyone has read that this curving street of odd little shops was Rowling's model for Diagon Alley. Some versions add that a joke shop traded for years near the bottom, an obvious Weasleys' Wizard Wheezes, and older Edinburgh hands do remember a real joke shop down at the West Bow end, which gave the legend a lovely piece of supporting evidence.

Then in July twenty twenty-two, Rowling pulled the tablecloth off. No real street inspired Diagon Alley, she wrote. It came out of her head. She'd never seen ninety-nine percent of the places claiming to be the inspiration, and she'd never seen Victoria Street at all when she created Diagon Alley, though she has since, she added dryly, because she lives here. In the same thread she waved away the Greyfriars gravestone tours. The city's whole inspiration map, in three tweets. York's famous Shambles has received the same treatment, as have various cafes, schools and alleyways across Britain. She once told a fan that a claimed Diagon Alley in Exeter was nothing like the one in her head.

So why does the legend keep growing when the author herself keeps killing it? Partly money, obviously. Potter tourism is worth serious revenue to Edinburgh, and nobody puts up a plaque saying the author never walked here. But the deeper reason is more forgivable. When a story matters to millions of people, they want it to have a geography. Pilgrims need shrines. If the real Diagon Alley existed only inside one woman's head, it can't be visited, so the collective imagination goes looking for the nearest worthy stand-in, and Victoria Street, curved, colorful and slightly unreal, was always going to be elected. The claim is false and the casting is perfect, and both things are true at once.

There's one more irony, and it's the best thing on the street. Edinburgh didn't need to invent a wizard for Victoria Street, because it already had one. In the sixteen hundreds, the West Bow's most respected resident was Major Thomas Weir, a fiercely devout soldier famous for his public praying. In sixteen seventy, unprompted, Weir confessed to a secret life of appalling crimes and sorcery, and Edinburgh executed him for witchcraft. His sister claimed his walking staff had magical powers. For over a century afterward his house stood empty, the most haunted address in the city, and locals swore his ghost galloped out of the Bow at midnight. The Wizard of the West Bow was terrifying local legend three hundred years before anyone drew a lightning bolt on a boy's forehead. Cities don't grow legends around beloved books by accident. This one has had the habit for centuries.

Room Five Five Two

At the east end of Princes Street, the Balmoral's great clock tower rules the skyline. It was built in nineteen oh two as the North British Station Hotel, the railway hotel for Waverley below, and its clock is famously kept three minutes fast so that travelers don't miss their trains. The one exception is Hogmanay, New Year's Eve, when it's set to the correct time for the midnight bells, then nudged fast again. Remember that the whole story you've been following started with a woman getting off a train at Waverley. It ends upstairs in this hotel.

By early two thousand and seven, Rowling was deep in the seventh and final book, *Deathly Hallows*, and struggling to finish it at home. Her solution was the classic writer's retreat, minus the budget constraints of nineteen ninety-three. She checked into room five five two at the Balmoral and worked. The contrast is the whole story in miniature. Fourteen years earlier she'd been stretching a single coffee through a writing session because that was what she could afford. Now she was finishing the series in a five-star suite overlooking the castle. And on the eleventh of January, two thousand and seven, in that room, she wrote the last words of the last book. *Deathly Hallows* was published that July and became the fastest-selling book in history.

Then came the vandalism. The suite contained a marble bust of Hermes, and Rowling, in the giddiness of the moment, wrote on it in ink. J K Rowling finished writing *Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows* in this room, five five two, on eleventh January two thousand and seven. She has cheerfully admitted to defacing the thing. The hotel's response was not to bill her for damages but to canonize the object. The bust sits in the suite to this day, protected under glass, and the room has been rebranded the J K Rowling Suite. Its door is painted purple, fitted with a brass owl door knocker, and renumbered five five two and three quarters, in honor of a certain railway platform. Sleeping in it costs north of a thousand pounds a night, and superfans book it well ahead, some to attempt their own novels at her writing desk.

It's worth pausing on what Edinburgh and Rowling have meant to each other across those fourteen years. The city sheltered her at her lowest, and it has collected the dividends ever since, in tourism, in bookshop windows, in walking tours. She, in turn, has stayed. She wrote all seven books wholly or partly here, took an honorary degree from the University of Edinburgh in two thousand and four, and remains an Edinburgh resident. Whatever you make of the shakier shrines around town, the cafes and gravestones and painted streets, this one is documented in her own handwriting, on a Greek god's marble shoulders, behind glass, five floors above the station where she first arrived.

Hogwarts Is in Scotland

Here's a question the books never quite answer out loud, and Rowling only settled in interviews. Where is Hogwarts? The clues are all there. The Hogwarts Express leaves from King's Cross in London and travels north for an entire day, into mountains and moorland, arriving after dark. Rowling spelled it out in a two thousand and two television interview. She had always imagined Hogwarts in Scotland, she said, and a British reader would work it out, because a day's journey north from King's Cross lands you here. The castle by its great lake sits somewhere in the Highlands, unplotable, hidden from Muggle eyes. So for the rest of your Scottish week, you are, canonically speaking, in Hogwarts country.

The filmmakers took the geography seriously, and their choices created a second wave of pilgrimage sites, these ones genuine. The Hogwarts Express itself is played by the Jacobite, a real steam service that still runs in summer between Fort William and Mallaig on the West Highland Line, regularly voted among the most beautiful railway journeys in the world. Its signature moment, in the films and in life, is the crossing of the Glenfinnan Viaduct, a great curved span of twenty-one concrete arches completed in nineteen oh one by the contractor Robert McAlpine, nicknamed Concrete Bob for his enthusiasm for the then-novel material. When Harry and Ron chase the train in the flying Ford Anglia in *Chamber of Secrets*, it's the

Glenfinnan Viaduct beneath them. On summer days now, hundreds of people stand on the hillside to watch the steam train take the curve, and the sound carries across the valley like a film score.

Below the viaduct lies Loch Shiel, which served as the Black Lake beneath Hogwarts in several films, with other Highland lochs, Eilt and Morar among them, filling in for close-ups and shorelines. A tiny islet on Loch Eilt, crowned with a few wind-bent pines, became Dumbledore's island tomb. And in a nice collision of legends, the head of Loch Shiel is where the actual Jacobites began. The tall monument on the shore marks the spot where Bonnie Prince Charlie raised his standard in seventeen forty-five and launched the rising the steam train is named for. One valley, two doomed romantic causes, one real and one fictional, sharing a railway bridge.

Which brings us to your own itinerary, because this family is spending several days inside the landscape that made everyone believe a hidden castle was plausible in the first place. Tomorrow's boat to Inchcolm delivers you to a ruined island abbey in the Firth of Forth, grey towers, seabirds, water on all sides, about as wizarding-world a site as Britain offers without a ticket from Universal. Stirling gives you a working royal castle on a volcanic crag, great hall and all. And from the top of Arthur's Seat, Edinburgh's own extinct volcano, you can look north toward the Highlands and understand the trick. Scotland genuinely is scattered with lochs that hide things and castles with no roads to them. The books only claimed one more than the maps show. In Goblet of Fire, Hermione explains that Muggles who stumble close to Hogwarts see only a mouldering ruin with warning signs. Scotland has hundreds of mouldering ruins. Officially, every single one of them is nothing. Keep an eye on them anyway.